

The Pursuit of Happiness

The hedonic treadmill made me stop and think because I can see how fast I adapt to good things. When I hit a goal I have been chasing for a long time, I feel excited, but it fades quicker than I expect. Then the goal becomes normal for me. My mind starts reaching for the next thing to chase. I do not want my happiness to depend on an endless cycle of wanting more.

The process principle felt like the clearest explanation for why the finish line never feels as big as I imagine. He mentions “Pleasure comes more from making progress toward goals than from achieving them,” and I realized I keep skipping over the progress part. I rush through my days and treat effort like a cost instead of something that can actually bring satisfaction. A change I want to make is to notice small progress on purpose, even when it is not impressive yet.

The adaptation principle also challenged the way I predict my emotions. When something goes wrong, I act like I will feel that way forever, and when something goes right, I expect it to fix everything. Haidt shows us that we often misjudge how long emotions will last, even for major events. He mentions, “Many people think they would rather be dead than paraplegic. But they are mistaken,” reminded me that people adapt more than they think. When I feel overwhelmed, I want to focus on the next small step I can control, not the whole future at once.

I also liked that Haidt does not reduce happiness to mindset alone. He says, “Happiness comes from within, and happiness comes from without,” and he summarizes it with $H=S+C+V$. That helped me accept that my habits matter, but my circumstances matter too. Jeremy Adam Smith adds that “Happiness starts to look less like an individual choice and more like a product of institutional, economic, and historical forces” That perspective made me less harsh on myself and more understanding toward others, because not everyone is starting from the same conditions.

The money and prestige section felt like a warning about comparison. Haidt mentions, “The elephant cares about prestige, not happiness” and I realized how often I am tempted by things that mainly signal success instead of actually improving my life. When I chase image based goals, the satisfaction disappears quickly and pushes me right back into the treadmill. I want to focus less on looking successful and more on spending time and energy on experiences that actually connect me with people.

The relationships section was the most practical for me, especially Haidt explains how deeply relationships shape long term happiness. He said, “Good relationships make people happy, and happy people enjoy more and better relationships than unhappy people,” which made me think about relationships themselves. Instead I want to invest more patience, communication, and attention into them before problems grow.

Lyubomirsky's work also helped me think about what habits I should realistically build. She explains that "The activities with the highest Fit Scores are likely to be the ones that will feel most natural and enjoyable to you." That made me realize happiness habits only work if they match my values and personality. Instead of copying what works for someone else, I want to choose a few practices that genuinely fit my life and commit to them consistently. Overall, what got my attention most is that happiness is not one single decision or one final achievement. It is shaped by daily effort, realistic expectations. Supportive relationships, and the world around me are also why my happiness could be shaped. The biggest change I want to make is to stop waiting for one big success to make me happy. Instead build small habits, strong connections and steady progress that I can actually sustain.

Results - Your Best-Fitting Activities

These are the top four activities most likely to increase your happiness.

Note: These will get populated as you fill in the ratings above.

- 1. Savoring life's joys (Fit Score = 6.00)**
- 2. Developing strategies for coping (Fit Score = 5.33)**
- 3. Expressing gratitude (Fit Score = 3.67)**
- 4. Doing more activities that truly engage you (Fit Score = 3.17)**

Extra credit:

I honestly really connected with this writing because most of the time i think about what my purpose in this life is if AI is taking over everything. It really hit me when Freya said that the best defense you have is being a human, because I think we have to stay unique in a world where everyone's work looks the same through AI overuse.

Word count:

639

Sources I used:

Source 1: Haidt, Jonathan. The Happiness Hypothesis. Chapter 5 "The Pursuit of Happiness"

Source 2: Smith, Jeremy Adam. Social Critique of Positive Psychology

Source 3: Lyubomirsky, Sonja, adapted from Ken Sheldon. Person activity fit diagnostic.